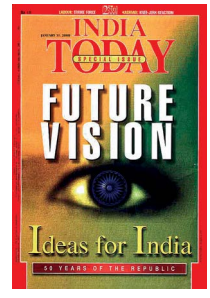
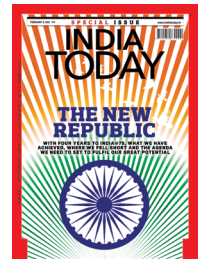
The 75th year of the Republic is no small milestone. The first half-century since 1950 was spent ticking the boxes of basic subsistence and getting our population above the poverty line, while amassing the firewood for economic growth. Across all domains, however, getting their everyday needs fulfilled entailed a high degree of drudgery for all Indians. As the new millennium dawned, a majority of our population was still below what I have termed as the Dignity Line. As many as 90 per cent of rural households still didn't have taps that brought water to their homes. Instead, women had to stand in long unruly columns at community hand-pumps or walk miles to draw water from wells or natural sources. Worse, most rural households didn't have pucca houses with toilets. Urban folk suffered similar daily deprivations, whether in commutes, paying bills for civic amenities or even getting a driving licence, where greasing of palms was a prerequisite for delivery. Not to forget the long pileup of vehicles to pay toll on highways. Endless hours were wasted everywhere in queues, and even then ordinary Indians could be thwarted by the system. Such were the indignities we had to routinely tolerate to get on with life. But it's been a quarter-century of rapid and self-conscious change. Now, as we embark on 2025, there are unmistakable signs of an 'Ease of Living' revolution that has transformed the everyday lives of Indians on a multitude of fronts.



January 31, 2000



February 8, 2021

For this special issue, we have curated 25 such markers of change. These are fundamental shifts that speak to the lived experience of Indians across all classes. Take the footprint of the Jal Jeevan Mission to bring tap water to rural households. From just 18 per cent as late as 2019, now an astonishing 80 per cent of rural households have tap connections; 2025 is the year they are pushing to hit 100 per cent. Millions of women can now divert to more fruitful activity all those tedious hours they spent merely to fetch water. There are three more markers from rural India. A palpable brick-and-mortar change greets us in the nearly 27 million pucca homes completed since 2016, all answering to the basic needs of hygiene and sanitation. For its proud owners, it's much more than a roof over their heads: it confers dignity, while having knock-on effects on health indices. As for rural mobility, an astonishing 771,392 km of all-weather roads have been laid and upgraded since 2000. As the next 62,500 km roll out by 2028-29, this will have village India entirely connected to India's road network. Also, the BharatNet initiative has already covered 214,000 gram panchayats with some 700,000 km of optical fibre cable—making over 80 per cent of the countryside 'service-ready' for high-speed internet. Taken together, this means enriching the lives of hundreds of millions.

As many as 15 of the changes we record have effected precisely such a material transformation in standards of living, bringing ease and solace to both rural and urban Indians. The domains that have undergone a sea-change include housing, transport and mobility, connectivity, governance, commerce and entertainment. Many change-making initiatives flow from innovative harnessing of technology. For instance, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), our centralised e-payment grid that's built on such a combination of ingenuity, vision and smart system design that it can be exported to the world. Between UPI and affordable data, they have brought us the ease of e-commerce. We now transact digitally from the comfort of our homes: from grocery to food and medicines, from the stock markets to a whole kaleidoscope of entertainment options, everything is at our beck and call. Outside, the FASTag system is easing our passage on highways.

Policymakers are also harnessing technology to cut through layers of bureaucracy: digitising land records, for instance, and easing building permission processes in municipalities. Add to that the new digitally empowered passport offices with superfast home delivery. Those old enough would recall the unending wait for a new passport. At major airports, check-in on the DigiYatra lane is a breeze: it has optical scanners that recognise the face and let the passenger in without the need to show an ID card. Digital payments have become commonplace, as have piped gas in metropolitan kitchens. The previously ubiquitous red gas cylinders are vanishing rapidly. Besides, home cooking is no longer a necessity as meals can get delivered home with a phone call.

Often changes in our lifestyle are taken for granted and how it was in the past is easily forgotten. However, all these changes tell a story of how life has become easier and more comfortable. Together, they are taking us towards a Better Bharat.

Happy Republic Day!

(Aroon Purie)